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UAE Presidential Court

PRESIDENT, VICE-PRESIDENT MEET ON LANDMARK DAY

President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan and His Highness Sheikh Mohammed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, met with government officials, marking 20 years of Sheikh Mohammed Bin Rashid's leadership of the Government, at Zabeel Palace, yesterday. **SEE ALSO P5**

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Maduro in NY jail as Trump says US will 'run' Venezuela

'WE'LL BE SELLING LARGE AMOUNTS OF [VENEZUELAN] OIL'

NEW YORK

Venezuela's president Nicolas Maduro was in a New York jail yesterday after a shock US snatch-and-grab raid to remove him from power and assert Washington's control over the oil-rich South American nation.

The US military carried out air strikes on Venezuela's capital Caracas early on Saturday. Commandos captured Maduro and his wife, who were flown to New York City where they face drug-trafficking and weapons charges.

Handcuffed and in sandals, Maduro was escorted by federal agents through a Manhattan US Drug Enforcement Administration facility, a video posted by the White House on social media showed. "Good night, happy new year," the 63-year-old leftist was heard saying in English. Maduro has led Venezuela with an iron fist for more than a decade after the death of his charismatic mentor, former president Hugo Chavez.

As news of his seizure rippled out, exiled Venezuelans waved flags and celebrated in plazas from Madrid to Santiago. But the streets in the Venezuelan capital



AFP

Venezuelan President Nicolas Maduro (centre) is escorted by DEA agents inside the headquarters of the US Drug Enforcement Administration (DEA) in New York on Saturday.

remained quiet and many residents were apprehensive about what is to come.

Trump said he was "designating people" from his cabinet to take control, but gave no further details. The Republican leader appeared to reject the possibility of the country's opposition taking power, instead saying he could work with Maduro's Vice-President Delcy Rodriguez.

Rodriguez poured cold water on that prospect, demanding Maduro's release and vowing to "defend" the country.

In it for the long haul

But Trump indicated US involvement is likely for the long haul, adding to the confusion over how the country would be run. "We're going to stay until such time as the proper transition can take place," he said.

Trump's interest in tapping into Venezuela's massive crude reserves also became clearer.

"We're going to have our very large United States oil companies ... go in, spend billions of dollars, fix the badly broken infrastructure," he said. "We'll be selling large amounts of oil."

Secretary of State Marco Rubio said yesterday the US is ready to work with Venezuela's remaining leaders if they make "the right decision." "We're going to judge everything by what they do, and we're going to see what they do," Rubio told CBS News' "Face the Nation" programme. "I do know this: that if they don't make the right decision, that the United States will retain multiple levers of leverage."

— AFP

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